# Twins are birds #2

Why did Aramis die?

Why is home printing so painful?

THE PROBLEM

# Why is printing from home so painful?

Most of the world is busy jamming digital trackers into every crevice they can find - turning bad dreams, half-arsed jogs round the park, irregular bowel movements and panic attacks into pristine bits of data - transcendent promises of metaversal orderliness.

Meanwhile home printers are feverishly working in the opposite direction - like demented flagellants they reclaim the messed up nature of the flesh - scrunching up paper, spilling ink, spitting out random pages and refusing to operate until you jiggle about with their insides to dislodge all the staples.

Everyone loves an iconoclast - printers are doing noble and lonely work - but surely not everything physical needs to be so damn frustrating? The big print companies have had decades on this problem, but they still can't seem to fix it. Are they just sadistic or is something else going on?

# Why did Aramis die?

*"It was a seductive idea, Aramis-really quite ingenious. It became more and more technical, less and less comprehensible to the uninitiated, and a source of anxiety for the Finance Ministry. I watched it die. I didn't intervene in its death; I didn't have to."*

**The Aramis project was developed in the 1970s as a revolutionary new public transport system. Like the DLR, but with smaller carriages and stopping at *Gare d'Austerlitz* instead of Mudchute.**

Conceived as an energy efficient alternative to cars, Aramis promised the privacy of private transport coupled with the efficiency of public networks.

Aramis was technically brilliant, efficient and reliable, but the project went nowhere - after 17 years under development - it fell apart. By 1987 Aramis was dead and gone.

But everyone who worked on the project insisted there was nothing wrong with it, so who killed Aramis?

# Twins are birds

*"Of what ends am I the means? Tell me! You hid from one another in order not to admit that you didn't want me. You built the CET the way human couples produce one child after another when they're about to divorce, trying to patch things up."*

Aramis was a demanding pain in the arse.

For the politicians Aramis was politically demanding. The project lasted from the TGV days of *Pompidou* to the Opéra nights of *Mitterrand* all the while needing more money and constantly slipping between the gaps of prototype and final project.

For the engineers Aramis was technically demanding. They needed to develop a new coupling system that would stop the carriages from smashing each other to bits.

But neither group was stepping up in the way they needed to. They were working together but only within the confines of their job descriptions.

# Why did Aramis die?

*"Silence is for me to bear, not you. You humans need to talk, argue, get mad, that's your role in this imperfect world. A frightening conspiracy of silence is what imposed silence on me. I would exist, on the contrary, if you had spoken, you silent ones."*

**The politicians and engineers were speaking for themselves, but not for each other, they kept to their own separate camps rather than seeing that the separation itself was the problem.**

And because they were separated from each other, nobody could see the relationship that sat at the heart of it all - nobody was speaking to or for Aramis.

No one considered the possibility that the design of the technology itself could change and for 17 years it stayed the same - pristine, unadulterated, pointless. They worked around it rather than with it, no dialogue, no adjustment, no desire to make the whole thing work as it could have done. No love.

# Twins are birds

*"Machines are not anonymous and interchangeable. Each one has its own trajectory, its own career, its own calling."*

- Bruno Latour, 1996

Mockup of Proposed car from the Aramis PRT system

## Technology Needs Love to Work

Love. Latour's very precise choice of word. Not care - which is too loose, or advocacy which is too technical but the word Love because it describes **a commitment that exceeds what it has been asked to do.**

Love as a commitment to think about projects as alliances that are technical and political but that are also social and emotional.

Love would have meant the engineers turning up to the funding meetings or the politicians learning about the coupling mechanisms.

Love would have meant seeing Aramis as more than just a technical or a political problem - but as something that had social implications and emotional costs - things that needed fixing but ended up being neglected instead.

Love would have meant a true alliance, technology working with politicians working as engineers working as politicians working with technology.

THE SOLUTION

## Why is home printing so painful?

Home printing is not painful because printers are terrible products - but because the alliance they are in don't work.

Printers need love too - toners need replacing, firmware needs updating - jams happen, paper runs out. That's a lot of care and patience required. iphones and saucepans and wellington boots need care too, but the love you put in matches what you get back.

Meanwhile the other part of the alliance - The print manufacturers - sell printers at a loss, placing all their focus on ink and toner. They might have some love for their printers - but they see them as peripheral to the alliance they really care about, which, ironically, is the peripherals.

No one cares about printers.

AFTERWORD

# Bruno Latour, and the agency of objects.

Bruno Latour. Mr A.N.T. Super jargon heavy, very obtuse, easy to accuse of being pretentious. Basically all the things people hate about academics.

But all the density and all the obscurity was all the point - Latour wanted density because he thought social systems were dense - full of people and objects all competing for attention and influencing each other in unexpected ways.

Stripping all that back for this post is perhaps a form of sacrilege but it is worth doing for a message that feels pretty loud and clear and urgent for today.

Technology doesn't just serve our wishes, it demands things from us in return.

This seemed radical in the 80s - but now as people fry their brains using a technology that literally talks back to them and tells them what to do and how to think - it feels almost tame.

People should know about Latour.

# Twins are birds

## Thanks for reading

## Read some more

Aramis, or The Love of Technology - Bruno Latour, 1996

Reassembling The Social - Bruno Latour, 2005

Of Bicycles, Bakelites & Bulbs - Wiebe Bijker, 1995

Aircraft Stories - John Law, 2002

## Read more Twins are birds

**https://jimmott-collab.github.io/twins-are-birds/**